

Home and abroad: On India and the Indian student

India must improve research **infrastructure** to serve its students

The ongoing **programme** of **revoking** the visas of foreign students in the U.S., **ostensibly** for opposing the country's foreign policy, **is** a direct outcome of the **xenophobic tendency** in the Trump administration. The danger is that the 'Make America Great Again' **movement** that **propelled** Donald Trump into the Presidency **may** soon **permeate** deep into campus life too. In any case, the **number** of Indian students enrolling in U.S. universities **has** been on a downward trend since last year — even before the **drumbeats** of **hostility** started. Indian students are already finding other countries such as Germany attractive for lower costs and greater **flexibility** to self-fund their education through work. Enrolment **figures** for September this year **will demonstrate** how attractive the U.S. still is for Indian students despite the **looming** cancellation of the Optional Practical Training programme that offered a **segue** for foreign students to working in the U.S. **All this**, together with the **defunding** of research and **arm-twisting** of universities in a country known to value academic freedom, **has indeed** lowered, if not **upended**, the **regard** that people outside had for the U.S.

Many countries have **sought** to **leverage** the decline of the U.S. as a destination for talent. Reports talk about European institutions welcoming **disgruntled** U.S.-based researchers, **ironically** noting that scientists and researchers **fleeing persecution** greatly contributed to American progress in the past. For a while now, Indian returnees have been driven in-part towards a desire to come back home or even serve their motherland. Professional achievement or the opportunity to do high-end research has not always been a big **driver** towards India attracting back its people. While, **outwardly**, new **vistas** have opened, research opportunities have expanded, and the fight for funds is less intense, **in part** due to the encouragement given to private institutions, much work remains to be done. **Loosening up** the government's **purse strings** and **goading** private institutions to invest in research more may only be the starting point. What **often puts off** returnees is the daily struggle in India. The struggle not only **characterises** everyday social life but also the workplace. **Collaboration** between institutions or even across departments **is a tough sell**. The **suffocating** social norms and **hierarchies** are a **downer**. Lastly, the academic **freedom** that Indians are used to enjoying elsewhere **will** need to be recreated. That would require a complete **overhaul** in the Indian government's attitude to liberal values and towards foreigners, which often **borders on** the Trumpian. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.
- **In part** (phrase) – Partly, partially, in some measure, to some extent अंशतः
- **A tough sell** (phrase) – something that is difficult to persuade people to do or try राजी करना मुश्किल है

Vocabulary

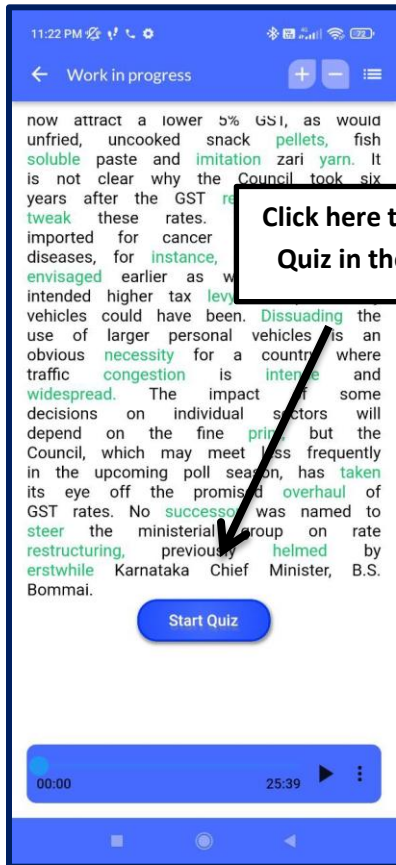
1. **Infrastructure** (noun) – framework, foundation, system, setup, support structure अवसंरचना
2. **Revoke** (verb) – cancel, annul, withdraw, rescind, invalidate रद्द करना
3. **Ostensibly** (adverb) – apparently, seemingly, on the surface, allegedly, supposedly प्रकट रूप से
4. **Xenophobic** (adjective) – anti-foreigner, intolerant, nationalist, prejudiced, ethnocentric विदेशियों से डर या नफरत करने वाला
5. **Propel** (verb) – drive, push, launch, thrust, move forward आगे बढ़ाना / प्रेरित करना
6. **Permeate** (verb) – spread, penetrate, diffuse, infiltrate, saturate फैलना / प्रवेश करना
7. **Drumbeat** (noun) – call, signal, warning, repeated sound, steady beat लगातार संकेत / चेतावनी
8. **Hostility** (noun) – animosity, hatred, opposition, aggression, enmity शत्रुता
9. **Flexibility** (noun) – adaptability, versatility, openness, elasticity, willingness लचीलापन
10. **Demonstrate** (verb) – show, prove, exhibit, present, reveal दिखाना / प्रमाणित करना
11. **Looming** (adjective) – impending, approaching, threatening, upcoming, about to happen मंडराता हुआ
12. **Segue** (noun) – transition, shift, progression, move, link क्रमिक परिवर्तन
13. **Defunding** (noun) – withdrawal of funds, financial cut, disinvestment, budget reduction वित्त पोषण में कटौती
14. **Arm-twist** (verb) – pressure, coerce, compel, force, manipulate दबाव डालना
15. **Indeed** (adverb) – truly, certainly, in fact, undoubtedly, definitely वास्तव में
16. **Upend** (verb) – overturn, disrupt, topple, destabilize, invert उलट देना
17. **Regard** (noun) – respect, esteem, admiration, opinion, consideration सम्मान / दृष्टिकोण
18. **Seek** (verb) – look for, pursue, search, request, try to obtain तलाश करना / माँगना
19. **Leverage** (verb) – use, exploit, capitalize on, take advantage of, apply प्रभावी उपयोग करना

20. **Disgruntle** (verb) – displease, upset, annoy, dissatisfy, irritate नाराज़ करना
21. **Ironically** (adverb) – paradoxically, unexpectedly, curiously, sarcastically, satirically विडंबनापूर्ण ढंग से
22. **Driver** (noun) – motivating factor, influence, cause, trigger, initiator प्रेरक तत्व
23. **Outwardly** (adverb) – externally, on the surface, visibly, apparently, superficially बाहरी रूप से
24. **Vista** (noun) – prospect, view, opportunity, vision, outlook दृश्य / संभावना
25. **Loosen up purse string** (phrase) – increase spending, release funds, spend freely, allocate budget liberally खर्च बढ़ाना
26. **Goad** (verb) – urge, provoke, push, spur, incite उकसाना / प्रेरित करना
27. **Often** (adverb) – frequently, regularly, usually, repeatedly, many times अक्सर
28. **Put off** (phrasal verb) – discourage, repel, deter, dissuade, postpone टालना
29. **Characterise** (verb) – describe, define, portray, mark, depict विशेषता बताना
30. **Collaboration** (noun) – cooperation, partnership, teamwork, alliance, joint effort सहयोग
31. **Suffocating** (adjective) – oppressive, stifling, restricting, smothering, overwhelming अत्यधिक नियंत्रित
32. **Hierarchy** (noun) – order, ranking, structure, tier, chain of command पदक्रम
33. **Downer** (noun) – disappointment, discouragement, setback, negative factor, letdown निराशाजनक तत्व
34. **Overhaul** (noun) – reform, renovation, restructuring, transformation, revamp सुधार / पुनर्गठन
35. **Border on** (phrasal verb) – be close to, resemble, verge on, approach, approximate निकट होना

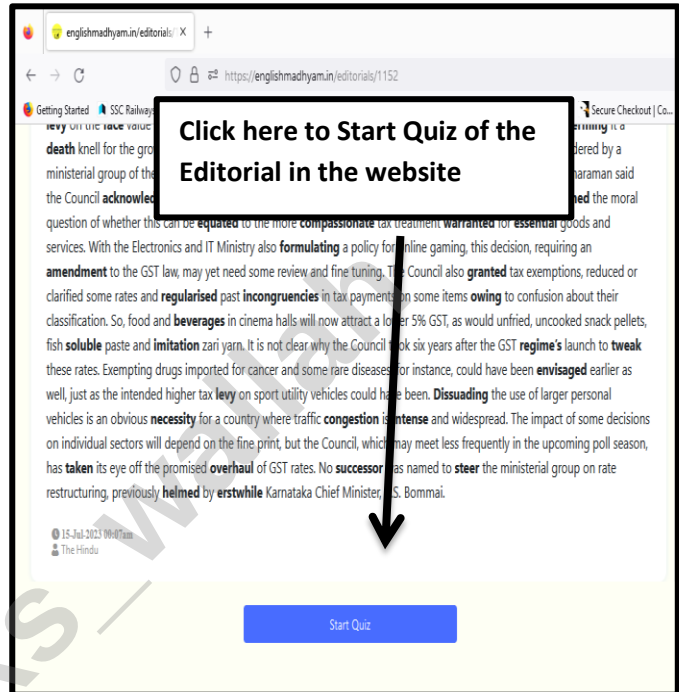
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Visa Revocations in the U.S.** – The U.S. is revoking foreign student visas, seemingly for political dissent, reflecting rising xenophobia linked to Trump-era policies.
2. **Impact on Indian Students** – Even before these crackdowns, the number of Indian students choosing the U.S. was already declining.
3. **Shift to Other Destinations** – Countries like Germany are becoming more attractive due to lower tuition costs and flexible work-study options.
4. **OPT Programme Uncertainty** – The potential cancellation of the Optional Practical Training (OPT) in the U.S. adds to Indian students' uncertainty.
5. **Decline in U.S. Academic Appeal** – Defunding of research and erosion of academic freedom in the U.S. has diminished its global academic reputation.
6. **European Opportunity** – European institutions are benefiting by welcoming talented researchers disillusioned with the U.S.
7. **Historical Irony** – The U.S. once benefited from persecuted scientists fleeing other regimes, but now risks losing talent for similar reasons.
8. **Indian Returnees** – Some Indians are returning out of a desire to contribute to their homeland, not necessarily for better research opportunities.
9. **Limited Research Drivers in India** – India's appeal to returning researchers is hampered by underdeveloped infrastructure and limited incentives.
10. **Growth in Private Institutions** – Although private sector involvement in research has increased, it's still inadequate for substantial impact.
11. **Funding Challenges** – There's a need for the Indian government to increase funding and encourage private sector investment in research.
12. **Workplace Struggles** – Daily professional life in India often involves bureaucratic hurdles, lack of collaboration, and outdated hierarchies.
13. **Academic Collaboration Gaps** – Inter-departmental and inter-institutional cooperation in India remains weak and difficult.
14. **Need for Academic Freedom** – Returnees expect the academic freedom they enjoyed abroad, which is often lacking in India.
15. **Reform Needed in Government Attitude** – A shift towards liberal values and openness is essential to attract and retain global academic talent, avoiding a 'Trumpian' style of governance.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



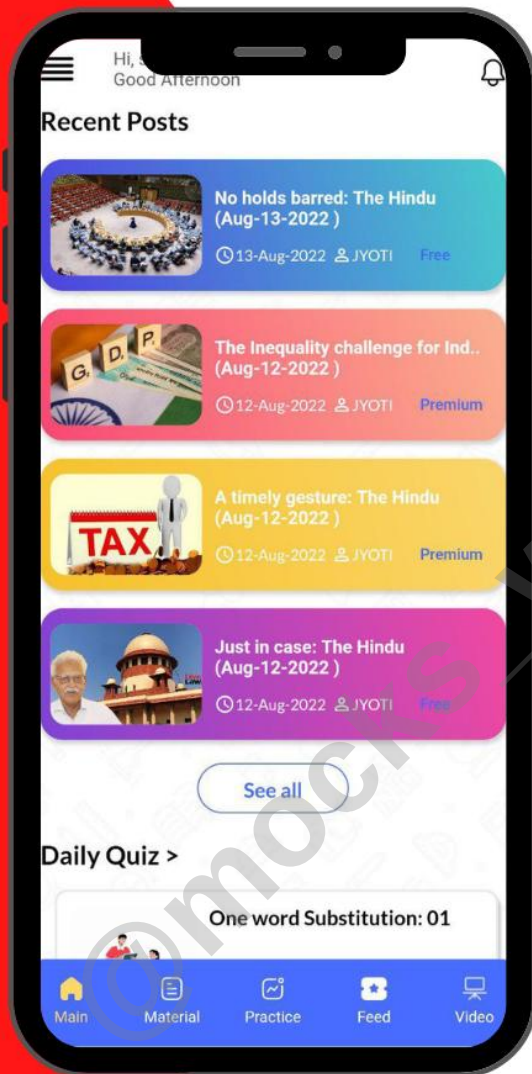
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